to 45 in Engineering this year, Acharya Narendra Dev College climbed in Science.

19 **We introduced 'Most Improved Colleges'** to capture the five-year growth in rank between 2022 and 2026, measured as percentage improvement, not a single year's leap, rewarding sustained transformation.

20 **New entrants prove the rankings are not a closed club.** Sri Guru Tegh Bahadur Khalsa College, Jesus and Mary College and Ramnarain Ruia broke into the Arts top 25 for the first time this year, RV College of Engineering breached the private top 10.

21 **We rank cities and zones, not just the nation.** City-wise top-threes and four-zone regional rankings mean a student in Patna, Kochi or Chandigarh can find the best option within reach.

22 **The methodology itself is the longest-running innovation.** Conducted with MDRA since 2018, with weightages held steady to allow honest year-on-year comparison, the survey's greatest achievement is consistency.

23 **Every ranking rests on 112+ indicators per stream.** These include: Intake Quality & Governance, Academic Excellence, Infrastructure & Living Experience, Personality & Leadership Development & Career Progression and Placement. The parameter-wise scores show why a college ranks where it does.

24 **MDRA evaluates colleges on current-year data**, cross-checks submissions, and normalises by student numbers so a large college can't win on bulk alone.

25 **Reputation is measured but kept in its place.** A perceptual survey of 1,889 informed respondents, senior faculty, recruiters, career counsellors and final-year students across 27 cities, is weighted against hard data in a 60:40 split for professional courses and 50:50 for academic ones.

26 **Only serious, settled institutions make the cut.** A college must offer full-time, in-classroom courses and have graduated at least three batches by 2025 to be considered.

27 **Participation has more than doubled in eight years**—from 988 colleges in 2018 to 2,016 in 2026.

28 **Small towns are quietly producing top-30 colleges.** Thoothukudi for low-cost Arts, Karkala and Mangaluru for technology and Dental.

29 **Women's colleges dominate where it matters most.** Miranda House, Lady Shri Ram, Daulat Ram, Jesus and Mary, Mount Carmel, Stella Maris—women's institutions sweep the top ranks in Arts, Science and Psychology.

30 **A handful of colleges are genuinely all-rounders.** Hindu College tops Arts and Science and ranks high in Commerce, CHRIST appears across Commerce, Science, BCA and Engineering. ■

METHODOLOGY

How the Colleges were Ranked

With more than 50,000 colleges across India, the 30th annual edition of India Today Group's ranking of colleges in India intends to make critical career decisions easier for aspirants based on rich information and data, establishing it as the gold standard for other stakeholders such as recruiters, parents, alumni, policymakers, public and institutions. Since 2018, this survey has been conducted in association with reputed Delhi-based market research agency Marketing & Development Research Associates (MDRA) and has been widely appreciated for its consistency. Colleges were ranked across 14 streams—Arts, Science, Commerce, Medical, Dental, Engineering, Architecture, Law, Mass Communication, Hotel Management, BBA, BCA, Social Work and Fashion Design.

During objective ranking, MDRA carefully attuned more than 112 performance indicators in each stream to provide comprehensive, balanced comparisons of colleges. These were clubbed into five broad parameters—'Intake Quality and Governance', 'Academic Excellence', 'Infrastructure and Living Experience', 'Personality and Leadership Development' and 'Career Progression and Placement'.

Moreover, to give more realistic, relevant and accurate information, MDRA evaluated colleges based on current-year data. The ranking tables also give parameter-wise scores to provide deeper insights on key aspects of decision-making by various stakeholders. In addition, from 2023, the survey has come out with the first-ever ranking of colleges in major subjects, such as Economics, History, English, Psychology, Sociology, Political Science, Physics, Chemistry, Botany, Zoology, Hindi and Sanskrit, based on the objective data submitted by the colleges.

The ranking was done in multiple steps.

↘ An extensive desk review of MDRA's database and secondary research was conducted to prepare a list of colleges in each stream. Only colleges offering full time, in-classroom courses and that have churned out at least three pass-out batches till 2025 were considered. In 12 streams, undergraduate courses were ranked. In Mass Communication and Social Work, postgraduate courses were evaluated.

↘ Experts with rich experience in their fields were consulted to frame the parameters and sub-parameters for different streams. Indica-